

Overview & Purpose

Background information on why this research is needed

The purpose of this research is to validate and refine the design for the MVP trial session calendaring prototype.

Research Methods

How we will approach our research to gather the information we need

- Interview
 - Duration of 60 minutes
 - Scheduled remotely via zoom
- Contextual Inquiry over Zoom

Engagement Groups

A list of people we will speak with to learn more about their experiences

In order to gather diverse perspectives from people that utilize DAWSON, we met with 2 Calendar Clerk Supervisors

Interview Guide (1st Round)

Questions we will reference to guide our conversations with users

Thank you for your time today. Today we'll be looking at some ideas we have that may make the calendaring process easier. Dawson has a great deal of information in it already that could help with the calendaring process that is done mostly outside of Dawson. We discussed quite a few potential ideas for how it could help but for this we focused in on one in particular, it could assist in determining how many sessions a location should have per term based on the number of cases ready for trial. It could also be clever and respect things like federal holidays, or not scheduling sessions at the same time that would have the same IRS office supporting them.

REMINDER TO RECORD!

Would it be okay if I record this meeting for note-taking purposes?

Do you have any questions before we get started?

So let's start with a question:

1. If we told you there was a place in Dawson where you could work on term planning (that wasn't just the trial session report), where would you expect to find it?
2. What roles would need to see the terms? What roles need to be able to create/manipulate the terms? (Docket and Petitioners and clerk of court. Docket creates specials, not involved in calendaring yet)

(Walk through the prototype up to the calendar and stop)

3. What are your initial reactions to this workflow?
4. What are your thoughts on where you would find the term builder?
5. What are your thoughts on the phrase 'term builder'?
6. What are your thoughts on the hard coded rules?
7. How should specials be indicated on this calendar? What color do you use for specials today?
8. Would it be useful to have the total number of sessions per week displayed?
9. On the terms table, what other columns do you want to see at a high level?

(finish walking through prototype)

10. Do you have any other thoughts or feedback on this flow right now?

We will be continuing to expand this flow and we have a number of things up our sleeves for future meetings like how you will be able to control the rules that create the draft calendar. But for now we just wanted to keep it simple and get initial reactions to get your brain thinking about it.

Interview Guide (2nd Round)

Questions we will reference to guide our conversations with users

Thank you for your time today. Today we wanted to ask more questions about scheduling a trial term.

REMINDER TO RECORD!

Would it be okay if I record this meeting for note-taking purposes?

Do you have any questions before we get started?

1. Confirm the months of each term (Fall Sept-Dec; Winter Jan-Mar; Spring Apr-June) Are they always the same year to year?
2. When do you start calendaring for the year?
3. How does the trial session planning report help with calendaring?
4. What are other uses for the trial session planning report?
5. Borrowed spaces and court leased spaces - is there a maximum number of weeks/trial sessions that can be held at those locations?
6. Do location based remote sessions have the same case loads as in person sessions (100 for regular, 125 for small)? What about standalone remote sessions?

7. How are swing sessions determined?
8. How do facilities communicate which sessions they have booked courtrooms for?
9. Booking Marshalls - does it matter for your process or is this solely on facilities?
10. Talk about how special sessions are selected by STJ during the calendaring process. How are you notified there will be a special session? Is that 'dictated' by a judge or is there a process where they propose it to the court?
11. After a term has been set, when and how would assigning high priority (checkbox in case info) to cases happen? How is high priority determined?
12. The first approval of the draft calendar is by the Chief STJ - talk about this process.
13. Who decides which judge is assigned to which session?
14. Once the calendar is approved by the Chief Judge, how does the calendar become sessions? Are they manually created in Dawson?
15. Can changes be made after a calendar has been approved by the Chief Judge? If they are able to change after finalization, should a newly added session appear on the calendar? Do you update the PDF of the calendar on the public website?
16. Why would a trial session need to be added manually after calendaring has happened? Are there any rules outside of the ones for calendaring that these need to follow? What are the reasons it would be canceled?
17. Summer terms (July and Aug) are not calendared so how do cases end up in these months?
18. How long does it take on average to calendar a term? How long does the spreadsheet part take?
19. Is there a list of which IRS offices support which tax court locations?
20. Describe what your ideal solution to calendaring in Dawson is.
21. How do you balance old and new cases on case load?

Outcomes

After conducting the focus group, the transcripts and recording were reviewed and the content synthesized for analysis. This led to a contextual inquiry where 2 UX Designer & Researchers directly observed the team calendar and a trial term over Zoom.